

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1997-03-11

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

with joyful and thankful hearts we announce the successful acquisition after many years of difficult negotiations and the subsequent demolition a few days ago of the building which stood as the last obstacle to the completion of the first two terraces of the Shrine of the Báb at the foot of Mount Carmel.

245

Role of National Spiritual Assembly in Private

Businesses Run by Bahá'ís

17 March 1997

The National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of New Zealand

dear Bahá'í friends,

1997 and has asked us to respond as follows.

The House of Justice commends you for the careful thought you have given to the issues raised about the relationship between the institutions of the Faith and those business enterprises which appear to be helpful in the attainment of Bahá'í objectives. Your account of the present understanding of the National Spiritual Assembly indicates that you are in a good position to offer suitable guidance to any believers who have concerns over these matters.

In drawing attention to private businesses set up by believers, and in encouraging the Bahá'ís to give serious consideration to availing themselves of such services, a National Assembly should not be regarded as endorsing

these businesses, if that is understood to imply some form of guarantee about the efficacy of the service provided by any such business. The analogy of the books produced by Bahá'í publishers used in your letter is quite apt;

in publicizing a book or article from such a publisher, there is no implicit

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56assurance that the document is free from error or even that the National Assembly is entirely in agreement with every point made therein. however the National Assembly can well conclude that the product of a business conducted by bahá'ís (or even non-b ahá'ís) is useful in the advancement of the interests of the faith and can properly decide to convey information about it to the believers.

Turning now to your question about a development trust becoming involved in the establishment of private business enterprises, no general ruling is appropriate at this stage in the development of the faith. every case should be considered on its merits. There is a vast difference between the institutions of the faith becoming involved in a private business set up with the principal purpose being simply the accumulation of profit, and the institutions fostering and supporting individual and group business initiative aimed at the uplifting of people who have historically been deprived or suppressed. other factors to be considered include the stage of development of the bahá'í community, the resources at its disposal, the preservation of its reputation and the legal restrictions imposed by its incorporation. As specific matters arise in the future, you are welcome to turn to the house of justice for guidance on issues you feel unable to resolve through your own consultation or through advice from the counselors.

with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]